

The Advantages of an Adult Education Center

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Every Chabad House has an engine driving its growth and brings new people through the door, whether the preschool, summer camp, or day school, the shul or the women's mikva, the kosher restaurant, or the Friendship Circle. This engine can change over time as the shliach and his shlichus evolve. For Chabad of the Conejo, the engine is shiurei Torah.

The beauty of focusing on Torah is that the more people learn, the more other Jewish activities branch out naturally and become necessities. When parents appreciate and learn Torah, they want a Jewish school for their kids, a summer camp, kosher food, a mikva, tefilin and mezuzos. תלמוד תורה כנגד כולם; everything else flows from there.

Adult education ensures that your Chabad House continues to grow and does not stagnate. People want to learn and be inspired. The more people learn, the thirstier they become, thereby forcing you to challenge yourself, as well.

Another great advantage in focusing on adult education is that it will bring many new people through your doors. By branding yourself as a Jewish educational institution, you are not asking anyone to become a member, so it is a lot less threatening. An academic class in an educational and professional environment can attract people who would not come to a Chabad shul otherwise. Eventually, as you develop personal relationships, the defenses will drop, and they will be open to getting involved in other programs, as well.

In addition, learning cultivates a relationship with a baalebos like nothing else does, which naturally manifests when you have to approach him for fundraising purposes. In that sense, adult education, if done right, covers itself many times over.

PRIMARY PURPOSES

There are three objectives that shluchim must have when building an adult Torah education center:

1. לימוד התורה לשמה

First, we must help people recognize the importance of Torah study in their growth as Jews and as human beings.

Many Jews have the sense that simply being active in Jewish life is enough. They donate to the Federation, they belong to a temple, they attend synagogue on high holidays, and they bar mitzva their kids. But they do not realize that there is something more: A Jew, by definition, learns Torah, and it is a lifelong journey.

Today, unfortunately, more than half of all American Jews have never opened a Chumash. In their temples, they might take a paragraph or a chapter

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Rabbi Isaac Schwei's Classic Answer

When I was a bochur, I went to Westlake, California for three consecutive summers to run a summer camp. During these summers, I had, boruch Hashem, managed to enroll a number of kids in an after-school Talmud Torah. In the winter of תשמ"ז, as I was learning for my smicha in Montreal, I got a call from Rabbi Yehoshua Gordon, who told me that the talmud Torah in Westlake was in immediate need of someone to run it. For these kids, this was their entire Jewish education, and it was an emergency. I already knew the place and the kids, so he asked me to take over the program.



I asked my rosh yeshiva, Rabbi Isaac Shwei, olov hasholom, what to do. He gave me a classic answer, "Which hat do you want me to wear, the hat of a rosh yeshiva or a chossid? If you are asking me as the rosh yeshiva, the answer is clearly no. A bochur belongs in yeshiva. But if you are asking me as a Lubavitcher chossid, then, as the Yiddishkeit of these kids is at stake, I think that this is a question for the Rebbe."

Together, Rabbi Shwei and I wrote to the Rebbe and received a rather unique answer. The Rebbe told me to go to California but remain under Rabbi Shwei's hanhola, that Rabbi Shwei should determine how many hours I would spend in the yeshiva in Los Angeles and how many in the Chabad House of Westlake. I should fly back to Montreal every few months to be farhered. The Rebbe had circled Rabbi Shwei's name numerous times on my letter, as well as the hours that I proposed to be learning, and then concluded, "על פי כל זה, יקבל ההצעה בשעה טובה ומוצלחת."

Once I left, I was officially still a talmid of Montreal Yeshiva, but I was learning in LA and teaching in the Conejo Valley. I would have chassidus and morning seder in LA, leave for afternoon talmud Torah, then return to LA in the early evening and learn until midnight.

As a sidenote, my first lesson in shlichus came from Rabbi Binyomin Klein. When we had sent the letter in to the Rebbe, I wrote that the matter was urgent. I received the Rebbe's answer on Thursday, left Montreal that day, went to 770 for Shabbos, and had a flight set for Sunday morning. Rabbi Klein saw me in 770 on Shabbos and asked, "What are you doing here? If the matter is urgent, and the Rebbe told you to go to California, you get on the plane Thursday and arrive in California Friday!"

each week and talk about it, but they do not actually read or learn the words inside.

The first step is to cultivate an appreciation, a thirst, for Torah. Torah is not just a scroll in an ark written by an ancient scribe, an artifact that makes for a nice prop for dancing and for bar mitzvas, rachmana litzlan. Our challenge is to "take the Torah out of the ark" and bring it to them personally. We need to help them discover the wisdom of Torah, its boundless depth, grandeur, and insights, its intellectual and moral beauty and profundity.

It is important to show that the Torah is literally the foundation of all morality today, that the great ideas of the American Founding Fathers upon which this great country is built are all from Torah. A book that explains this in detail is *The Gift of the Jews* by Thomas Cahill (a non-Jew!). If you can show an American Jew today that the very country in which he lives and of which he is so proud is, at its core, based on Torah's principles and ideas, he will feel proud to be connected to it. He will understand that the soundest principles of a civilized society come from a Torah that is *his* Torah, and it is, therefore, well worth his while to make time in his busy schedule to invest in it, understand it, and own it.

2. גדול תלמוד שמביא לידי מעשה

Next, we must show people that Torah is the source of all mitzvos, traditions, and Jewish observances. Most American Jews have heard of mitzvos. Perhaps their rabbi gave them a matza or asked them to put on tefilin, but they've never seen their sources in the sacred texts. When they see the words for themselves, their approach to mitzvos invariably changes drastically. Suddenly, mitzvos become much more real and relevant.

We all struggle with getting people to the next step. Learning inside makes a monumental difference. Yiddishkeit becomes that much more alive, and they are inspired to progress in their Jewish journey. The mitzvos that they have learned about become challenging and invigorating.

To give an example: We conduct a weekly mid-day Chumash study group that has been going on for eighteen years. We review each posuk slowly and in depth. This class grew from a small handful of people to about a hundred people, boruch Hashem. My colleague Rabbi Yitzchok Sapochkin-sky would offer the participants of each class the opportunity to put on tefilin, and he would always get a few volunteers. Then, we reached the chapter in sefer Shemos where the mitzva of tefilin is first



Crowd at a recent Conejo Jewish Academy lecture

mentioned. We spent a few weeks discussing tefilin and how they are made, maintained, and checked. The next time Rabbi Sapochkinsky offered tefilin, the entire class lined up. There was a total change in attitude. The difference was clear; it spoke to them, they connected to it, and it became *theirs*, and thus it has remained, boruch Hashem.

The math is simple: The more Torah one studies, the more one observes.

3. מקום תורה

The third objective is to make your Chabad House the address for Torah study in your community.

All too often, our critics (and I'm talking about the "fairminded" ones here) have said, "Chabad is a great outreach organization. If you need a menorah or want to put up a mezuzah, sure, call Chabad. They're good for that type of stuff. But for Torah study, that's not the place. For intense Torah study, come to us."

We cannot allow anyone to downgrade a Chabad House. Chabad is Chochma, Bina, and Daas; it can, should, and must be the undisputed center for Torah in the community. Every Jew should know that if he wants the highest, deepest, and most comprehensive level of Torah education, he will find it only at Chabad. The Rebbe would want and expect nothing less, and we owe this to him.

START SMALL, BUT BE PROFESSIONAL

When introducing an adult education program, it is important to realize that you are asking people to give up some of their extremely

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valuable free time. You are cutting into their relaxation and family time, and you are competing with restaurants, TV, and movies. They might need to find babysitters or make other arrangements in order to show up. Your class has to be able to compete. It has to be professional. It has to be worth their efforts.

> CLASSES MUST BE WELL PREPARED. Glancing over a sicha minutes before the class starts won't cut it. There are no shortcuts. Good classes take significant preparation, no matter how quick, bright, or knowledgeable the teacher is. I suggest to start thinking about each class at least a week in advance.

> KNOW YOUR CROWD, AND MAKE SURE YOU CONNECT. Think about your specific students for each class, anticipate their questions, and be ready with thorough, well-informed answers.

> WRITE NOTES IN ADVANCE. Don't worry that it might make you seem less proficient; the truth is quite the contrary. They will see you've put in substantial thought and consideration ahead of time, showing that you take your students and classes seriously.



Conejo Adult Education catalog series designed by Spotlight Design

IF YOU ARE GOING TO OFFER A GREAT CLASS, MAKE SURE THE MARKETING MATERIALS DO IT JUSTICE.

> START ON TIME. This is crucial to creating a professional and reliable environment. Even if few students arrive on time, begin and review later if necessary. They will learn to take you seriously.

> FINISH ON TIME. Even if the crowd is captivated, hanging on to every word, those with babysitters or other obligations must leave by a certain time. Establish a set ending time, and stick to it. Invite those who can to stay and discuss the class afterwards, but make people feel comfortable to leave on time.

> NEVER CANCEL A CLASS. This will forfeit momentum and consistency. Your consistency and punctuality are commensurate with the seriousness you engender within your students. If doing this causes you to show up late to weddings and bar mitzvas, so be it! When you explain that you've been teaching that night, it will only earn you and your class greater respect.

> THE LEARNING ENVIRONMENT SHOULD BE NEAT, CLEAN, COMFORTABLE, AND WELCOMING. It is essential that you make a good first impression and dispel any stereotypes, especially if you are attracting new people to your classes and programs. Provide paper and pens, and serve nicely prepared refreshments.

> CORRESPOND WITH YOUR STUDENTS DURING THE WEEK. Some questions might be distracting and need not be answered during the class. Welcome the question, even compliment it, but if it's too tangential, offer to get back to the student at a later time. You will be amazed by their surprise when you actually do. It means the world that "the rabbi remembered my question." It opens a valuable door for you into their lives.

> MARKETING MATTERS. If you are trying to break into a new audience or demographic, marketing is key. There is no such thing as too much PR. Utilize free press. Write press releases about classes and guest lecturers, not only so people see them and come, but also to get your name out there, so that whoever sees it realizes that the Chabad House is the local "university" for Judaism. If you are going to offer a great class, make sure the marketing materials do it justice.

> DON'T GET DISCOURAGED BY SMALL NUMBERS. Everything starts with two people. Even if you learn with two people for more than a year, keep it up. Eventually, חברך חברה איתך, and it will expand.

> THE TIME BETWEEN CLASSES IS INVALUABLE. Try to meet and get to know one new person each week. This is also a golden opportunity to invite guests for Shabbos. (However, doing this in the first few weeks can create fear of a religious agenda when they just want to try out a class. I would wait until the fifth week or so before extending such invitations.)

STRATEGY

I realize that some of what I will be outlining below might not be applicable to all Chabad Houses. For example, smaller operations might not be in a position to offer as many choices of classes (though very often local talent can be recruited as instructors for pay). I am simply sharing what has worked for us at Chabad of the Conejo and what is now quite a reputable adult education center, the Conejo Jewish Academy.

When we founded the Conejo Jewish Academy, our goal was, and remains, quite simple: to offer something for every single Jew in our community, from the person who just discovered his Jewish identity to the frum person with a yeshiva background. This is the key to a successful program. This could mean classes in Kabbala, ethics, Judaism for beginners, Talmud, chassidus, Tanya, parsha, halacha, women's issues, or other subjects of relevance to people's lives. Each community calls for a different combination.

We divide our yearly class schedule into three semesters: one in the fall (Simchas Torah through Chanuka), another in the winter (late January through Pesach), and a somewhat scaled-back semester in the spring (Pesach through Shavu'ous). We have a few classes over the summer, but not an official semester.

Within each semester, we offer five different study modules:

1. COURSES

Courses are focused on a specific topic or theme. The JLI courses are excellent and are bound to draw people. A doctor wants to know what Judaism says about Medicine and Morals; a Jewish lawyer wants to hear about Talmudic Law; a Jewish businessman has an interest in Business Ethics. Kabbala is always a big

The Rebbe's \$275,000 Brocha

We had opened a Chabad House in suburban Oak Park. After six years, the lease was up, and the landlord wanted a hefty increase in rent. We were trying to negotiate when we were abruptly informed that the landlord had entered into a lease with someone else and we had to get out.

Eventually, we found an ideal commercial property. I asked the Rebbe if we should pursue this property, and the Rebbe circled the word "pursue." The owner was asking for \$475,000, and because we didn't have the money, our lawyer drew up a complicated legal agreement that would have us pay \$60,000 every six months.

On the day of the closing, the owner, who was a veterinarian, told us that the deal was off. Apparently, that morning, a lawyer had come in to get his German shepherd vaccinated and heard about the agreement. He convinced the veterinarian not to go through with the deal. Naturally, we were very upset, especially since we had received an explicit brocha.

We finally ended up buying a house and spent more than a year getting it legally zoned for commercial use. The day we acquired the zoning permits, I was driving back from the courthouse with a baalebos. Suddenly, he turned to me and said, "Rabbi, now that we have the Chabad house in Oak Park sorted out, we need a real building for our Jewish Academy. I am in the mood to get you one. Have you ever pursued a building that just didn't end up working out?"



I immediately remembered the word the Rebbe had circled, "pursue." I told him about the veterinarian's property that had fallen through a few years earlier, and we drove directly there. When we arrived, we saw a note on the door saying that the bank had foreclosed on the building. He called the bank and, on the spot, made a deal to buy the building for \$200,000!

A brocha from the Rebbe is never wasted.

**WE BEGAN WITH
CHUMASH BREISHIS, AND
EIGHTEEN YEARS LATER,
WE ARE IN CHUMASH
VAYIKRA, STILL IN OUR
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sell. Not every course will appeal to every person, so it is, therefore, best to offer different types of courses simultaneously that will attract different crowds.

We also have a few courses that we refeature annually since there is always a need for them, and they consistently draw a new crowd. For example, *Living Judaism*, a six-week beginner's crash course for newcomers, and *Toward a Meaningful Life*, a course based on Rabbi Simon Jacobson's book. After all, who isn't looking for meaning in life?

Offer a description of the class in your pre-semester marketing so that the prospective student knows exactly what to expect and what he will walk away with. A course can run anywhere from two to eight weeks with a clear start and end

date. Extending beyond that will cause you to lose focus. People feel safe knowing what they will learn and how long it will take. Of course, the beauty of JLI is that all this is done for you.

Charge a minimal fee per course. This not only helps cover your costs, but, more importantly, if it's a professional, quality class, people expect a fee. Not charging

won't make your product more desirable, but more suspect as to your professionalism (or hidden agenda). If someone says he can't afford it, you can always gracefully waive the fee for the individual. "I understand, but I really want you there, so please come as my guest."

Track who attended what and when so that you know your constituency's specific interests and can extend individualized invitations for future classes that would seem "up their alley."

2. STUDY GROUPS

These are the classic Chabad House weekly classes that go on indefinitely, not limited by the semesters. This is for a more committed student, and it is here that more substantial Torah knowledge is accumulated. We have numerous study groups on a variety of subjects. For example, we

have a Chumash class that goes slowly and methodically through each posuk in great depth. I have found this to be a much more enjoyable learning experience than trying to squeeze an entire parsha into one week. We began with Chumash Breishis, and eighteen years later, we are in Chumash Vayikra, still in our very first cycle. If all goes well, G-d willing, I think we are slated to finish Chamisha Chumshei Torah by 2040!

Study groups can be hosted at the Chabad House, but we have found that they are enhanced by having them hosted in the home of a baalebos. As the baalebos would like his living room full, he promotes the class and invites his relatives and friends to attend. This attracts new faces, and what's more, you bring Torah into his home and life.

In textual study groups, like Talmud or Mishna, students should be divided based on level, even if that means more classes (and more work) and fewer students in each class.

Personally, I see these shiurim as a different breed from the courses, and I don't charge for them.

3. WORKSHOPS

This is very hands-on and is different than a course or a study group. They are how-to guides (challah baking, preparing a Shabbos meal, kashering a kitchen, etc) where participants expect to get their hands dirty and perhaps take something home that they prepared. These have a limited run.

4. LECTURES

A one-time lecture, if done right, can have a huge impact on your community. It has many advantages over a course. The speakers themselves attract new people, especially if well known. You can choose timely, relevant, complex, and provocative topics. Plus, you are only asking people for a very limited amount of their time.

The lecture is especially powerful if the topic has a resonant and enduring message and comes from a powerful speaker, whether from a prominent rabbi like Rabbis Manis Friedman, Immanuel Schochet, or Yossi Jacobson, or someone with an inspiring life story like Tova Mordechai or Yisroel Haber. People connect well to life journeys.

A hotel ballroom lends prestige to an event, but it can be expensive. Sometimes it is well worth it, but weigh carefully who the speaker will attract



Recent Conejo Jewish Academy lectures

and if it makes sense for you.

A lecture can also serve as effective PR for the Chabad House. We host Dennis Prager quite often, and he can draw close to a thousand people. In my introduction, I make sure to mention our other functions, and Dennis invariably praises Chabad, so it's good for marketing and credibility all around.

It was a lecture like this that led to the opening of Chabad of Agoura. Dr. Judah Landes, of blessed memory, a prominent psychologist from Stanford University who became shomer Shabbos, challenged people to walk to shul. That night, a group from Agoura asked me to open a Chabad house in their neighborhood so they, too, could walk to shul, which we did, subsequently.

5. SEMINARS

A seminar is an in-depth presentation lasting several hours or a full day. This works best on a Sunday with meal breaks and refreshments.

Similar to lectures, but more in depth, you can either have multiple speakers or advertise "a day with the scholar." Expect smaller crowds, and make sure you thoroughly tackle the subject and keep people's attention. Some of our successful seminars include *A Day for the Jewish Woman*, as well as *The Spiritual Cosmos* with Rabbi Manis Friedman.

People expect to pay for lecturers and seminars.

SHABBATONS AND TRIPS

In addition to the five modules which make up the Academy, we also offer Shabbatons and other trips from time to time. These can be life-changing. When people leave their homes for a group trip, they are open, carefree, and more themselves.

An annual event that has worked beautifully for us is our women's shabbaton, where the men stay

home with the kids. This is affordable and easy to pull off, and the women really look forward to it (even if the men don't).

Israel trips are definitely transforming. You can do a study-group tour and learn about the places you visit. Larry Ritter is a great person to help you coordinate such a program.

צו איינעמן די וועלט!

When you learn Torah with someone, you have direct access to their nefesh Elohis, and it is truly an influential experience.

The only mitvza about which the Rebbe used the expression צו איינעמן די וועלט, captivating the world, is limud haTorah. May we fulfill this horaah literally, and may we be zoche to דעה את ה' כמים לים מכסים!

CONCLUDING MESSAGE FOR FELLOW SHLUCHIM

One of the keys to success in shlichus is focusing on the individual. It's not always about big numbers, big buildings, and big headlines. Indeed, every time the phone rings, you receive a letter in the mail, or you meet someone on the street, there should be an element of excitement; someone is reaching out to you, and you have a chance to affect that person in a profound way. When you are speaking or learning with someone, give him your fullest undivided attention and realize that this is your shlichus, for him, right there and right then. Let each individual feel that, at that moment, there is nothing in the world more important or precious to you than his own spiritual wellbeing. 

An edited transcription from the 2009 Kinus HaShluchim workshop given by Rabbi Moshe Bryski, director of Chabad of the Conejo, California